JONATHAN ZEMPEL

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Summary

Senior Principal Engineer with 30 years of experience, specializing in enterprise design systems. Founding architect of Zendesk Garden, scaling it to 95%+ UI adoption. Expert at aligning cross-functional teams around shared technical standards, WCAG 2.2 AA compliance, federated contribution, and generative AI interfaces.

Experience

Zendesk, San Francisco, CA **Apr '14 – Mar '26**

Sr. Principal Engineer

- Technical Leadership & Scale: Architected a federated contribution model scaling Garden to 95%+ of all UI interactions across dozens of globally distributed engineering teams.
- Generative AI App Architecture: Scaled the core design system into the foundational UI layer for Zendesk's generative AI app builder, powering a new product line driven by AI-generated interfaces.
- Core Ecosystem Delivery: Directed technical strategy and component delivery for Zendesk's 2026 unified navigation overhaul, seamlessly unifying eight distinct product lines.
- Governance & Accessibility: Led a cross-functional team maintaining zero-regression UI libraries and spearheaded initiatives embedding strict WCAG 2.2 AA compliance into primitive layers.

Pickwick & Weller, San Francisco, CA **Aug '12 – Apr '14**

Lead Developer

- Architecture & Redesign: Led a major e-commerce web and mobile redesign for a fashion startup to enhance customer acquisition and UX layout.
- DevOps Modernization: Engineered the transition from manual deployment workflows to a fully automated continuous deployment (CI/CD) pipeline.
- Integration Infrastructure: Authored robust, open-source integration APIs for Stamps.com and FedEx to optimize core fulfillment logistics.

Genomera, Palo Alto, CA **Feb '10 – Aug '12**

Architect

- Platform Architecture: Conceptualized and built an internet-scale social platform designed to modernize clinical trials utilizing DNA-based health data.
- Full-Stack Execution: Architected the complete technical stack, implementing a continuous delivery culture that safely deployed to production multiple times daily.

Skills

- *Design Systems & Frontend Architecture:* React, Design Tokens, Vite, Storybook, Tailwind CSS
- *Languages & Ecosystems:* TypeScript, JavaScript, HTML/CSS, Node.js, Python, SQL
- *Accessibility & Standards:* WCAG 2.2 AA, Semantic HTML, Screenreader Optimization
- *AI & Productivity Tooling:* Claude, Copilot, Storybook MCP, Figma Make